

# Two Movements, One Machine

Alberta wants out. America wants back. A 1987 essay on Québec explains both.

Working draft, subject to revision.

-----

On October 19, 2026, Albertans will vote on a question that does not quite ask what it sounds like it asks. Across the border, millions gather under a banner that says the real country has been taken and must be given back. These look like opposite stories. They run on the same machine, and a Canadian essay from 1987 already drew the blueprint.

The essay is Maurice Charland's study of the peuple québécois. Its claim is simple and unsettling. A movement does not speak to a people that is already there. It speaks the people into being, and in the same motion it tells them what they were always headed toward. You are this kind of person, the story says, and people like you want this. By the time you notice the second half, you have already nodded at the first.

Watch Alberta with that in mind. The province is young, born in 1905, with no centuries-old nation to summon. So the "people" gets built from grievance instead: equalization, pipelines, a distant capital that takes and does not give. That works as far as it goes. What it cannot do is make the grievance lead anywhere fixed. The governing law is actually called the Alberta Sovereignty within a United Canada Act. The ballot question asks only whether to start a legal process toward some later, non-binding vote. And the polling tells the same story from the ground: around 60 percent say they would vote No, even among people who feel every bit of the grievance.<sup>1</sup> The identity is real. The exit it is supposed to point at keeps coming loose.

Then there is the part the rhetoric cannot talk its way past. Treaties 6, 7, and 8 were signed before Alberta existed.<sup>2</sup> They already constitute a people, with rights that a court can enforce. In May 2026 a judge threw out the separation petition because the government had not consulted the First Nations whose treaty rights a breakup would touch.<sup>3</sup> Québec learned the same lesson in 1995, when the Cree held their own vote and chose, by 96 percent, to stay in Canada no matter what the province decided.<sup>4</sup> You can call a new people into being. You cannot call an older one off its land.

Now turn the machine around and you get the American case. "No Kings," the true-America register, the sense that a real country was stolen and must be restored. The constitutive move is identical, a people summoned and told who they are. The only thing reversed is the direction of the promised end. Québec and Alberta point forward, to a sovereignty not yet won. The restoration story points backward, to a country said to have already existed and been taken. Even the movement's favorite number, the "3.5 percent" said to guarantee success, does constitutive work. It hands a crowd proof of its own size before the size is in.<sup>5</sup>

So the through-line holds. Forward or backward, thick nation or thin grievance, the operation is the same one Charland described. What the 2026 cases add is where it breaks. When the shared

substance is thin, the promised future comes loose from the identity, and people keep the “we” while dropping the exit. And when someone else was already constituted on the same ground, with treaties a court will read, the story meets something it cannot reword. The machine builds peoples well. It is worse at delivering them anywhere, and worse still at clearing the ground first.

---

## Notes

- Angus Reid Institute, Alberta referendum polling, 2026; CBC on the ballot wording; Alberta Sovereignty within a United Canada Act.
- Numbered Treaties 6–8 (1876–1899).
- Athabasca Chipewyan First Nation v Alberta (CEO), King’s Bench, May 13, 2026.
- Cree counter-referendum, October 1995.
- Chenoweth and Stephan, 3.5% rule; “No Kings protests,” 2025–2026.

Full citations and links in the Literature Review.